



RKDF UNIVERSITY, BHOPAL

Bachelor of Arts (B.A.)

Fifth Semester V

Course	Category	Subject	Subject Code
B.A.	Minor	Women's Writing	BA-EN 202
Total Credit: 6		Max.Marks:100 (Internal:40+External:60)	

SYLLABUS

Units	Topic	Duration (In Hours)	Marks
I	(a) Emily Dickinson: ' I cannot live with you', ' I'm Wife — I've finished that'[] (b) Sylvia Plath: 'Daddy', 'Lady Lazarus'[1][3] (c) Kamala Das: 'The Sunshine Cat', 'A Hot Noon in Malabar'[1][3] Keywords: FeminisM, .The confessional mode in women's writings	15	25
II	(a) Alice Walker: The Color Purple['] [3] 20 (b) Anita Desai: Cry the Peacock['] [3] Keywords: Womanism, Postcolonial feminism, Psychological fiction	15	25

III	.(a) Charlotte Perkins Gilman: The Yellow Wallpaper['] [3] (b) Tony Morrison: The Bluest Eye['] [3] (c) Mahashweta Devi: Draupadi, translated by Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak (Calcutta: Seall, 2002) [I] [3] Keywords: Race, Caste and gender, Motherhood and responsibility, Slave trade, Whites versus blacks, Gothic fiction	15	25
IV	(a) Mary Wollstonecraft: A Vindication of the Rights of Woman (New York: Norton, 1988) chap. pp. 1-19; chap. 2, pp. 19-38. [1] P1 (b) Virginia Woolf: A Room of One's Own (England: Penguin Books) [1]13} (c) Rassundari Debi Excerpts from Amar Jiban in Susie Tharu and K Lalita. eds., Women's Writing in India, vol.1 :New Delhi: OUP 1989, pp. 192- 202111 [3] Keywords: Social reform and women's rights	15	25

Unit I

Emily Dickinson: ' I cannot live with you', ' I'm Wife — I've finished that'[]

Sylvia Plath: 'Daddy', 'Lady Lazarus'[1][3] (c)

Kamala Das: 'The Sunshine Cat', 'A Hot Noon in Malabaf [1][3] Keywords: Feminism, .The confessional mode in women's writings

"I cannot live with You" is one of American poet Emily Dickinson's longest poems—and perhaps one of her most tormented. The poem's speaker tells a beloved that they "cannot live" together, not because their love is insufficient, but because it's overpowering. The thought of sitting beside this beloved's death bed (or worse, being separated from them in the afterlife) is simply too much for the speaker to bear; they'd rather endure the "Despair" of parting now than face those trials later. Like most of Dickinson's poems, this one wasn't discovered until **after her death**. It was first printed in the posthumous collection *Poems* (1890).

Outside of her poems, some of Emily Dickinson's most famous words are "I am one of the lingering bad ones" (The Dickinson Properties). She penned these words to a friend in her

account of the faith of everyone around her. She lived in a place and time in which the culture was embracing Christianity, and Emily Dickinson expressed on multiple occasions that she wished she could buy into the message like so many people around her were doing. She continued to claim, however, that she could not.

This feeling of her own inability to accept the message she wished to accept comes through in many of her poems including '*Because I Could Not Stop For Death*', '*Departed to the Judgement*', and '*I Heard A Fly Buzz – When I Died*' as well as many others. This belief comes through strongly in '*I Cannot Live With You*' in which the speaker refuses a marriage offer. She addresses her lover in this poem, offering every possible outcome of a union between the two of them, and claiming that all would end in despair.

I cannot live with You –
Emily Dickinson
I cannot live with You –
It would be Life –
And Life is over there –
Behind the Shelf
The Sexton keeps the Key to –
Putting up
Our Life – His Porcelain –
Like a Cup –
Discarded of the
Housewife – Quaint – or
Broke – A newer Sevres pleases –
Old Ones crack –
I could not die – with You –
For One must wait To shut the
Other's Gaze down –
You – could not –
And I – could I stand by
And see You – freeze –
Without my Right of Frost –

Death's privilege?

Stanza I

I Cannot Live With You opens with a curious line. The speaker is addressing a person and telling that person that she cannot live there with him. She tells him that to live with him “would be life”. It seems strange that she would not want to live with him if she herself admits that living with him would be life itself. But then she goes into deeper detail. She claims that “life is over there” and describes it as being something “behind the shelf”. It is almost as if the speaker does not believe herself to have access to life.

Stanza II

This stanza is a fascinating explanation from the speaker. She has already told the subject of *I Cannot Live With You* that she cannot live with him because that would be life, and life is not accessible to her. Now, she introduces another character- the Sexton. The Sexton was a person who would be in charge of the churchyard. He was once referred to as the gravedigger. In the days of the gravedigger and the churchyard watcher, people were occasionally buried alive. It is a terrifying idea, and because of this, the safety coffin was patented.

Somehow, the speaker does not feel in control of her own life, but at the mercy of one who might dig her up out of the grave. Still speaking to the same person she began speaking to, she says, “Our Life- His Porcelain- like a cup”. This reveals that the Sexton symbolizes God in *I Cannot Live With You*. However, the speaker does not portray a loving God that allows people to live, but one that seems to keep people in their graves, or on a shelf like a porcelain figurine or a decorative cup that gives him a pleasure to look at, to own.

Sylvia Plath: 'Daddy'

"Daddy" is a controversial and highly anthologized poem by the American poet Sylvia Plath. Published posthumously in 1965 as part of the collection *Ariel*, the poem was originally written in October 1962, a month after Plath's separation from her husband, the poet Ted Hughes, and four months before her death by suicide. It is a deeply complex poem informed by the poet's relationship with her deceased father, Otto Plath. Told from the perspective of a woman addressing her father, the memory of whom has an oppressive power over her, the poem details the speaker's struggle to break free of his influence.

Daddy

BY SYLVIA PLATH

*You do not do, you do not do
Any more, black shoe
In which I have lived like a foot
For thirty years, poor and white,
Barely daring to breathe or Achoo.*

*Daddy, I have had to kill you.
You died before I had time—
Marble-heavy, a bag full of God,
Ghastly statue with one gray toe
Big as a Frisco seal*

*And a head in the freakish Atlantic
Where it pours bean green over blue
In the waters off beautiful Nauset.
I used to pray to recover you.
Ach, du.*

*In the German tongue, in the Polish town
Scraped flat by the roller
Of wars, wars, wars.
But the name of the town is common.
My Polack friend*

*Says there are a dozen or two.
So I never could tell where you
Put your foot, your root,
I never could talk to you.*

The tongue stuck in my jaw.

It stuck in a barb wire snare.

Ich, ich, ich, ich,

I could hardly speak.

I thought every German was you.

And the language obscene

An engine, an engine

Chuffing me off like a Jew.

A Jew to Dachau, Auschwitz, Belsen.

I began to talk like a Jew.

I think I may well be a Jew.

The snows of the Tyrol, the clear beer of Vienna

Are not very pure or true.

With my gipsy ancestress and my weird luck

And my Taroc pack and my Taroc pack

I may be a bit of a Jew.

I have always been scared of you,

With your Luftwaffe, your gobbledygoo.

And your neat mustache

And your Aryan eye, bright blue.

Panzer-man, panzer-man, O You——

Not God but a swastika

So black no sky could squeak through.

Every woman adores a Fascist,

The boot in the face, the brute

Brute heart of a brute like you.

You stand at the blackboard, daddy,

In the picture I have of you,

A cleft in your chin instead of your foot

But no less a devil for that, no not

Any less the black man who

Bit my pretty red heart in two.

I was ten when they buried you.

At twenty I tried to die

And get back, back, back to you.

I thought even the bones would do.

But they pulled me out of the sack,

And they stuck me together with glue.

*And then I knew what to do.
I made a model of you,
A man in black with a Meinkampf look*

*And a love of the rack and the screw.
And I said I do, I do.
So daddy, I'm finally through.
The black telephone's off at the root,
The voices just can't worm through.*

*If I've killed one man, I've killed two——
The vampire who said he was you
And drank my blood for a year,
Seven years, if you want to know.
Daddy, you can lie back now.*

*There's a stake in your fat black heart
And the villagers never liked you.
They are dancing and stamping on you.
They always knew it was you.
Daddy, daddy, you bastard, I'm through.*

Unit II

Alice Walker: The Color Purple['] [3] 20

Anita Desai: Cry the Peacock ['] [3]

Keywords: Womanism, Postcolonial feminism, Psychological fiction

Analysis of The Color Purple

Alice Walker's epistolary coming-of-age novel, *The Color Purple*, is one of the most well-known works of American literature, given its deep socio-cultural impact. The novel paints a vivid, critical picture of life for an African American woman in the South in the early 20th century, portraying characters who gain the strength to defy its cultural limitations. Walker's protagonist, Celie, undergoes an arduous journey of self-discovery, helping her overcome conflicts that otherwise would oppress her. She, along with the book's other female characters, endures violence, subjugation, and abuse from male figures. However, as the events of the novel show, it is the strength and solidarity the women find in each other that helps them define

themselves and claim authority over their lives. Their relationships form the weapon with which they resist a world in which they are considered second class citizens.

Throughout the novel, Celie's major conflict is her struggle to establish her own voice and sense of self-worth, despite the sexual and emotional abuse she experiences at the hands of men. At the novel's outset, we learn about her father raping her and realize she has little personal agency. Nor does she have a confidante, and when Alphonso warns her to stay quiet about her abuse, she writes letters to "God" instead. Symbolic of the white patriarchal order, the being she addresses does not respond, leaving her trapped in a world with little say in what happens to her.

In her suffering, however, Celie is not alone. Walker initiates the spirit of sisterhood in descriptions of the relationship between Celie and Nettie. The bond between the sisters is evident early in the work, when Celie is forced to marry Mr. _____ and Nettie runs from Alphonso, coming to Celie for protection. When Nettie shares Mr. _____'s compliments with Celie, she demonstrates solidarity with her sister and reveals a degree of personal agency, having rejected Mr. _____'s advances. In Mr. _____'s house, Celie forms additional relationships with women, each helping her find her voice and strength. Sofia, she learns, is assertive and stands up for herself, offering a view into a woman of color's display of power and agency. Sofia's bond with her sisters lends one reason for her assertiveness, helping Celie understand that the spirit of sisterhood can give women the strength to resist.

In the novel's inciting incident, Shug's arrival at Mr. _____'s home, Celie's journey of self-discovery takes a significant turn. Her relationship with Shug—a singer who first appears as Mr. _____'s mistress—evolves from caregiver to friend, and eventually to lover. Throughout the rising action, Walker emphasizes the value of nourishing supportive female relationships. The

bond between Celie and Shug grows, and Celie appropriates a sense of her own sexuality, evident in her response to Shug when she tells her that she is still a virgin. Celie gains the power to redefine herself, learning to feel comfortable in her own skin.

Still, personal agency and rebellion against patriarchal oppression can have risks, including violent consequences, and Walker shows this in the stories of Squeak and Sofia. Sofia is beaten and thrown in prison for being an assertive Black woman, and when Squeak attempts to get her released, she is brutally raped. However, following this incident, Squeak finds her voice, literally and figuratively. She not only demands that Harpo call her by her real name, Mary Agnes, but she begins to sing. Walker thus defies a trope in which women are pitted against each other as sexual rivals, instead showing how support for each other can be empowering and liberating. Where women fail to bond and trust, as in Nettie and Corrine's story, they suffer; Corrine is left weak and eventually takes her life.

As the novel moves to its climax, Celie continues to discover her voice and self-worth. Letters throughout the work serve as a motif highlighting the power of narrating one's experiences, and Celie chooses to write letters to Nettie instead of to God. This is an empowering act symbolizing the fact that Shug has taught her to reject oppressive forces and ideas, including definitions of God. The climax of the novel occurs when Celie finally lashes out at Mr. _____ and announces that she is moving to Memphis. The relationships she cultivates with other women throughout her life finally imbue Celie with a sense of self, and she is able to speak up for the first time.

In the novel's falling action and resolution, this reclamation of power continues, manifesting in external change. Celie starts her own business and eventually becomes the owner of her childhood home. Her journey comes full circle, and as a grown woman, she has taken ownership

of her thoughts and opinions and is able to question what is right and wrong. Shug tells Celie at one point in the novel, “Us each other’s peoples now.” This sentiment extends to all the women in the novel, who support and uplift each other and thereby find a way to define themselves and reclaim power.

Summary of Cry the Peacock By Anita Desai

The novel “Cry the peacock” is written by famous Indian woman author Kiran Desai and it was originally published on 1963. Cry, the peacock is a first novel of Kiran Desai and it was awarded with Sahitya Akademi Award in 1963.

Summary of Cry the Peacock By Anita Desai

Anita Desai’s “Cry the Peacock” revolves around a girl named Maya, a daughter of Rai Sahib who is well known advocate in Lucknow located in Uttar Pradesh. Maya belongs to super rich family; she has one brother named Arjun who is living in America to complete his graduation. Maya is a loving daughter of Rai Sahib; he spends all his quality time with his caring daughter. He always tries to fulfil her daughter wishes no matter what it is and always take care of his daughter. The mother of Maya died a long time ago, since then her father is everything for her as he has taken care of her like mother. The story now features new character named Gautam, a good and very loyal friend of Maya’s father who sometimes behaves like an arrogant person. The thinking of Maya and Gautam is very different because of a huge difference in their age but still Maya’s father married her to Gautam.

Gautam is a spiritual person whereas Maya is a materialistic woman and he failed to satisfy her in bed as he is very older for Maya. Before marriage Maya used to be a very happy and passionate woman but after marriage her life is like hell because Gautam neither take care of her and nor give her proper attention. The story now introduces new characters, a mother and sister of Gautam who visits their home once in a week or sometimes once in a month and whenever they visit Maya's home, she gets some relief from her loneliness and sadness. The problem occurs when the pet dog of Maya named Toto died which makes her completely gloomy but for Gautam it's not a big deal because he believes it's just a dog which she can easily replace with another pet dog.

As the story move forward, we learn that Maya goes into depression as she wants someone who can take care of her and give her full attention. Like every girl, Maya had dreams and expectation from her husband, but all her dreams died with Gautam, who does not care for her and neither give her pleasure in bed which is a basic need of every married woman.

As the season of monsoon comes every single peacock cry and dance in rain to attract male peacock, whenever Maya saw any peacock dancing, she saw herself in a situation of peacock who is craving for her partner. The author believes only women can understand the pain of other women, but Maya's mother died a long time ago so she has no one to share her painful stories which she can't share with her father. She wants someone who can take care of her, someone with whom she can share all her pain and other stories. The story now jumps to a past life of Maya,

who before marriage goes to an astrologer who predicted that after four years of her marriage, one member from her family will die because of which Maya is very unhappy as she believes that she will die after four years of marriage. The story now jumps to present where Maya goes on the roof of their home with her husband, and they talk for a while but suddenly she pushes Gautam from roof due to which he died on the spot. She freed herself from arrogant husband who was not fit for her from the starting of their marriage. Afterwards, the mother and sister of late Gautam comes, and they send Maya to her father's home.

The story of novel ends with Maya whose father sends her to mental hospital for her mental health care.

Unit III

Charlotte Perkins Gilman: The Yellow Wallpaper

The Yellow Wallpaper is written as a series of diary entries from the perspective of a woman who is suffering from post-partum depression. The narrator begins by describing the large, ornate home that she and her husband, John, have rented for the summer. John is an extremely practical man, a physician, and their move into the country is partially motivated by his desire to expose his suffering wife to its clean air and calm life so that she can recover from what he sees as a slight hysterical tendency.

The narrator complains that her husband will not listen to her worries about her condition, and treats her like a child. She also suspects that there is something strange and mysterious about the

house, which has been empty for some time, but John dismisses her concerns as a silly fantasy. As part of her cure, the narrator is forbidden from pursuing any activity other than domestic work, so as not to tax her mind. She particularly misses the intellectual act of writing and conversation, and this account is written in a diary that she hides from her husband. They move into the room at the top of the house, which the narrator supposes is a former nursery since it has barred windows and peeling yellow wallpaper.

This repellent yellow wallpaper becomes a major force in the story, as the narrator grows obsessed with deciphering its seemingly incomprehensible, illogical patterns. She continues to hide the diary from John, and grows more and more convinced that the wallpaper contains a malevolent force that threatens the whole home. From her room, she can see a shaded lane, the bay, and an overgrown garden. When she can escape the attention of her husband and Jennie, his sister, she continues her study of the wallpaper and begins to imagine she can see a mysterious figure hiding behind the top pattern. She tries to convince her husband that they should leave the house, but he insists that she is improving and sees indulging her concerns as encouraging a dangerous, fanciful nature, when what is required is self-control. The narrator's depression and fatigue continue to worsen. Her fascination with the wallpaper takes over her life. In a series of increasingly short diary entries, she describes her progress in uncovering the secrets of its pattern, as she grows increasingly paranoid about the intentions of Jennie and John. She believes that the figure is a creeping woman, trapped behind the bars of the top pattern, and becomes determined to free her, and to keep the secret of her existence from her husband and his sister.

She surprises Jennie examining a scratched groove on the wall, and doesn't believe her excuse that she had been looking for the source of the yellow stains on the narrator's clothes. She begins to keep secrets even from her diary, and makes an initial, night time attempt to remove the wallpaper on the eve of their departure. Later, when all the furniture has been removed from the room except for the gnawed and heavy bed stand, she locks the door and throws the key down onto the front drive, and then proceeds to tear and tear at the parts of the wallpaper she can reach. Here, at the story's climax, the perspective shifts as the narrator's mental breakdown becomes complete, and in her madness she is convinced that she is the woman who was trapped behind the wallpaper. She begins to creep around the room in an endless circle, smudging the wallpaper in a straight groove. John breaks into the room and discovers her, and faints at the sight. She continues to creep endlessly around the room, forced to go over his prone body.

Tony Morrison: The Bluest Eye

Nine-year-old Claudia and ten-year-old Frieda MacTeer live in Lorain, Ohio, with their parents. It is the end of the Great Depression, and the girls' parents are more concerned with making ends meet than with lavishing attention upon their daughters, but there is an undercurrent of love and stability in their home. The MacTeers take in a boarder, Henry Washington, and also a young girl named Pecola. Pecola's father has tried to burn down his family's house, and Claudia and Frieda feel sorry for her. Pecola loves Shirley Temple, believing that whiteness is beautiful and that she is ugly. Pecola moves back in with her family, and her life is difficult. Her father drinks, her mother is distant, and the two of them often beat one another. Her brother, Sammy, frequently runs away.

Pecola believes that if she had blue eyes, she would be loved and her life would be transformed. Meanwhile, she continually receives confirmation of her own sense of ugliness—the grocer looks right through her when she buys candy, boys make fun of her, and a light-skinned girl, Maureen, who temporarily befriends her makes fun of her too. She is wrongly blamed for killing a boy's cat and is called a “nasty little black bitch” by his mother. We learn that Pecola's parents have both had difficult lives. Pauline, her mother, has a lame foot and has always felt isolated. She loses herself in movies, which reaffirm her belief that she is ugly and that romantic love is reserved for the beautiful. She encourages her husband's violent behavior in order to reinforce her own role as a martyr. She feels most alive when she is at work, cleaning a white woman's home. She loves this home and despises her own. Cholly, Pecola's father, was abandoned by his parents and raised by his great aunt, who died when he was a young teenager. He was humiliated by two white men who found him having sex for the first time and made him continue while they watched. He ran away to find his father but was rebuffed by him. By the time he met Pauline, he was a wild and rootless man. He feels trapped in his marriage and has lost interest in life.

Cholly returns home one day, finds Pecola washing dishes, and rapes her. When Pecola's mother finds her unconscious on the floor, she disbelieves Pecola's story and beats her. Pecola goes to Soaphead Church, a sham mystic, and asks him for blue eyes. Instead of helping her, he uses her to kill a dog he dislikes.

Unit IV

Mary Wollstonecraft: A Vindication of the Rights of Woman Summary

Mary Wollstonecraft writes *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* in response to French politician Talleyrand-Periér's pamphlet on national education. Her argument is that if women are not "prepared by education to become the companion of man, she will stop the progress of knowledge and virtue." Wollstonecraft believes that the neglect of women's education has caused great misery. Women are taught that romance is the primary goal of their lives, and they are not encouraged to develop their reason or virtue. In her critique of contemporary views of women's education, Wollstonecraft looks primarily at middle-class women and considers them first as "human creatures ... placed on this earth to unfold their faculties." She bases her argument on the belief that reason is what makes people human, that virtue is what distinguishes people from one another, and that virtue is attained through knowledge.

Wollstonecraft rejects the common argument that men and women should aim to acquire different virtues. She believes that although men and women generally have different duties in life, they should strive for identical virtues. But because women tend to be given a haphazard education, they are not given adequate opportunity to develop their reason and attain virtue. More often, they're taught to please men, preparing themselves for only a brief period of life—that is, courtship and early marriage. They aren't even prepared to build sustainable marriages or to care for their children effectively.

Because women are taught that pleasure is the overriding goal of their lives, they are never given the opportunity to struggle with adversity and thereby develop knowledge and virtue. Instead of learning to rely on reason, they're allowed to be driven by emotions and delicate sensibilities, which do not prepare women to be good wives and mothers. This neglectful education also leaves them especially vulnerable if widowed, or if seduced and "ruined" by a man—situations in which they are left without any means to support themselves financially.

Wollstonecraft specifically critiques several eighteenth-century writers on the subject of women's education. Her most detailed critique is of Jean-Jacques Rousseau, who argues that women only need to be educated inasmuch as it prepares them to serve men. She also dismisses Fordyce's sentimental sermons and Gregory's rules of decorum. She concludes that women have absorbed many of these oppressive standards because they haven't been taught to distinguish between reason and prevailing prejudices. She also addresses the importance of childhood impressions, the necessity of modesty for both sexes, and the distinction between external reputation and virtue.

Wollstonecraft sees duty—especially, for most women, the duties of motherhood and domestic life—as a vital building-block for families and thus, ultimately, for society. Because society pressures women to care primarily about external beauty, they have no incentive to attend to the duties nature has given them, leading to unhappiness and malformed family bonds. Women deserve the protection of civil laws in order to support them in fulfilling their duties. They should also have the option of studying medicine, politics, and business in order to have more occupational doors open to them, allowing them to be of greater use to society at large. Wollstonecraft concludes *A Vindication* with a proposal to establish free national schools for all children. Such schools—marked by strongly republican “jostling’s of equality”—would focus on creating good citizens, nurturing the virtues that have taken root at home. She advocates coeducation at every stage, believing this will allow relations between the sexes to develop in more natural and healthy ways. Educating girls in such schools will not distract them from domestic duties; rather, it will awaken their minds and prepare them the entire better to fulfil their duties, caring for their families based on reason and virtue rather than ill-informed prejudice and unruly feelings.

Finally, Wollstonecraft calls for a “revolution” for women, reiterating that their subordinate status is due to men’s prejudices and not to any inherent weakness. This will be proven once women are free to develop their understanding and affections. As women are released from ignorance, they will enjoy greater independence befitting rational creatures with human souls, and society as a whole will only benefit.